

BREACHING THE GRE

■ By Prabhu Chawla in Beijing

In the Middle Kingdom, words are quicker than actions. Words make the Chinese the world's finest artists of political seduction. They win the hearts of their guests by doing less and talking more. The cynics may call it posturing which was evident during Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's first official visit to China last week. Beijing was freezing at minus 9° celsius, but the Chinese leadership broke protocol and the prime minister was welcomed with unprecedented warmth. Operation Woo Manmohan was led by Chinese Premier Wen Jiabao, who held a private dinner for the visitor and his chosen five from the Indian delegation at a 300-year-old room in the Great Hall of the People. It lasted three hours—and no one knows how many words. There was, of course, the official banquet where top Chinese business, political and cultural leaders were present. Obviously, at the end, both sides called the meeting historic. And if spinmeisters from either side were to be trusted, it was indeed *Hindi-Chini bhai bhai* all over again. Eleven documents were signed and 10 meaningful declarations were made. Recognising the complexities of bilateral issues, both sides pledged to play a larger global role in a unipolar world. So they signed a document which was appropriately titled "A Shared Vision for the 21st Century of the Republic of India and the People's Republic of China". Manmohan had dropped a hint of this during the flight to Beijing when he spoke about the inevitability of both China and India playing an important role in world affairs.

HITTING IT OFF: What was most apparent about the meeting between the two premiers was their personal chemistry. Wen had done his homework on Manmohan. It was their sixth meeting in the last three years, and during informal exchanges, Wen said talking to Manmohan was like talking to his



BHAI-BHAI: (Above) Manmohan and Wen pose with their aides; (right) raising a toast

brother. "I feel I am talking to my elder brother" was how he put it. The cup of brotherly affection spilled over and whenever together, the two alternately held and then shook hands. If that wasn't enough, Wen walked almost 200 yards with Manmohan to see him off at the Great Hall of People. There again, there was another round of handshaking that could have rivalled Rajiv Gandhi's famous handshake with Deng Xiaoping exactly 20 years ago which could gain an entry into the Guinness Book as the longest handshake between two heads of governments. The next day even President Hu Jintao spent half an hour more than the allotted time with Manmohan and discussed with him the entire gamut of

